PHC 6707 Finding Health Research Information and Communicating Science
1 credit hour
Summer A 2025
Period 2: 9:30am-10:45am
Delivery Format: Online, Synchronous

Instructors: Mary E. Edwards, EdD; Margaret Ansell, MLIS; Courtney Pyche, MSI; Jane Morgan-Daniel, MLIS

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Office Hours:
Ms. Ansell: Tuesdays 2-3pm, Zoom
Ms. Morgan-Daniel: Wednesdays, 11am-12pm, Zoom
Dr. Edwards: Thursdays 3-4pm, Zoom
Ms. Pyche: Tuesdays, 11am-12pm, Zoom

Preferred Course Communications: We are happy to meet with you during the scheduled office hours listed above or by appointment. You are welcome to contact us via email or through Canvas messaging. If you email us directly, please use your UF email account and include your full name in the body of the email.

Prerequisites: PHC 6700 Public Health Research Methods, HSA 7707 HSR Research Methods, or equivalent course. Permission can also be given by instructors on request.

Purpose and Outcome:

Course Overview: The course is designed to refine knowledge of and facility with concepts, resources, and methods of searching for, assessing, storing, and disseminating health literature and data for quality research, publication, policy formulation, and grant-seeking. It is designed to develop critical thinking about topics including the formation of research questions, evidence, authorship, information resources, tools, and funding sources.

Course Objectives and/or Goals: You will explore topics including advanced literature searching, bibliographic citation software, the basics of conducting complex and systematic reviews, funding sources, data management, publishing best practices, information ethics and avoiding plagiarism.

When you complete the course, you will be able to:

- Successfully construct, evaluate, and refine search strategies for relevance to your topics of interest; and operate and critically appraise search interfaces in a variety of health-related literature databases;
- Evaluate bibliographic citation software packages as tools to store, organize, and format citation information, as well as for collaborating with other researchers;
- Locate and appraise biomedical and health-related funding opportunities and completed NIH grants to identify funding trends and grant-writing best practices;
- Appraise rigor and appropriateness of published and grey literature, as well as Open and Public Access publishing models;
- Critically assess published systematic reviews in terms of methodology and resources used;
- Justify the rationale for data reuse/sharing and best practices in data management;

- Apply principles of ethical use of information to note-taking, citation practices, and authorship determinations;
- Develop a research protocol that demonstrates synthesis of resources, tools, literature search strategies and addresses ethical and diversity considerations.

Instructional Methods

Online Class Meetings: Instructors and students will meet synchronously via Zoom twice a week. These meetings will include a combination of lecture, demonstration, application of key principles, discussion of critical analyses done during homework assignments, and real-time feedback from instructors. Students will be responsible for all the material presented in the course and assigned readings.

Readings and Resources: Required and supplementary readings and resources such as videos will be posted through Canvas. The reading list may be supplemented during the course.

Assessments: Assessment instruments will include written homework assignments, in-class participation and a research protocol as described in this syllabus.

What is expected of you: You are expected to participate in class sessions and complete all readings, assignments, and a research protocol. Additionally, you are expected to actively engage in the course throughout the semester. Your participation fosters a rich experience for you and your peers that facilitates overall mastery of the course objectives.

Description of Course Content: This course is designed to be practical, skills-based, and interactive. Each class session will involve a presentation by one of the instructors, one or more in-class individual exercise(s) putting the presentation content into practice, and follow-up group discussion.

Topical Outline/Course Schedule:

Class Number	Date	Topic(s)	Assignments and Exams
1	Tues, May 13	Introduction; course overview, introduction to bibliographic database structure and informational retrieval (search) theory	
2	Thurs, May 15	Searching the health literature: PubMed, MeSH, and MyNCBI	Homework 1 due
3	Tues, May 20	Searching the health literature: Web of Science and other literature databases	Homework 2 due
4	Thurs, May 22	Organizing your information: EndNote, Mendeley, Zotero, and other bibliographic management software	Homework 3 due
5	Tues, May 27	Data management: best practices, requirements, and resources	Homework 4 due
6	Thurs, May 29	Grants (what you need to know before and after submitting) and Search Strategy Review	Homework 5 due
7	Tues, June 3	Open/Public Access, preprints, publishing process, and grey literature resources	Homework 6 due
8	Thurs, June 5	Introduction to complex reviews	Homework 7 due
9	Tues, June 10	Systematic review methodology	Homework 8 due

10	Thurs, June 12	Ethical use of Information and best practices for publishing	Homework 9 due
11	Tues, June 17	Measuring and increasing publication visibility and impact	Homework 10 due Research Protocol due at midnight
	Thurs, June 19	No class – UF Holiday	

Homework assignments are due **before the beginning** of the next class period.

Course Materials and Technology: There are no required or recommended textbooks for this course. Journal article readings are listed in the Readings and Videos document or Files section and are available through Canvas. There are no materials and supplies fees assessed for this class.
For technical support for this class, please contact the UF Help Desk at:

- Learning-support@ufl.edu
- (352) 392-HELP - select option 2
- https://elearning.ufl.edu/student-help/

Academic Requirements and Grading

Homework Assignments (10 assignments @ 10 points each = 100 points total or 50% of final grade): Homework assignments give students an opportunity to apply and extend knowledge gained from class to a different question or scenario. For each class session, the homework assignment will typically consist of utilizing skills learned in the course to find and assess biomedical or health information or prepare documents to communicate information. Homework assignments are turned in through Canvas via text entry or file upload and are due before the beginning of the next class session (9:30am). Homework assignments will be assessed based on completeness, accuracy of response, and complexity of thought displayed. A grading rubric will be provided in Canvas the first day of class.

In-Class Participation (10 days of class @ 2 points each day = 20 points total or 10% of final grade): All students are expected to be engaged in class discussions of the course material and methodology. Class participation will be graded using a rubric provided in Canvas on the first day of class.

End-of-Course Project (88 points total or 40% of final grade): All students are expected to submit a research protocol that demonstrates enhanced skills and learning from the course. The research protocol must include the following: demonstration of search strategies from two different databases; proof of successful export of results into bibliographic software; justification of choices of sources and software; evidence of research impact of 2-4 potential study team members; justification of choice of 2-4 journals to target for submission; a data management plan; a list of potential grants or grantors; and evidence of consideration of ethical and diversity issues.

Grading

Item	**Description**	**Total points available**	**Percentage of final grade**
Homework	10 assignments, 10 points each	100	50%
In-class participation	For each class session except the first (10 meetings), 2 points each	20	10%
End of course project	Research protocol based on course content	80	40%

Grading Rubrics:

Homework Assignments

Criteria	1 point	2 points	3 points	4 points
Completeness	Misses multiple aspects of the assignment; does not answer most questions	Completes most aspects of assignment; answers most questions	Completes all aspects of assignment; answers all questions	
Critical Thinking & Reflection	Demonstrates minimal critical thinking or reflection; misses multiple major concepts addressed in the assignment	Demonstrates some critical thinking and reflection; misses one major concept or several minor concepts addressed in the assignment	Demonstrates extensive critical thinking and reflection; misses no major concepts addressed in the assignment	
Application & Extension of Learning	Demonstrates minimal synthesis of concepts addressed in other parts of the course	Demonstrates some synthesis of concepts addressed in other parts of the course	Demonstrates integration of learning from lecture, discussion, readings, and hands-on exercises	Extends course concepts to new situations or topics

Class Participation

Criteria	**Points**
Unexcused absence	0
Participated in discussion by adding opinions and answering questions	1
Posed thoughtful questions; contributed to discussion by integrating concepts, introducing novel perspectives, and drawing contributions from classmates	2

Final Project

Criteria Submissions will be assessed according to the following criteria:	**8 (Unacceptable)**	**12 (Needs Improvement)**	**16 (Meets Expectations)**	**20 (Exceeds Expectations)**
Content Research Protocol includes all the required	Protocol is incomplete; more than half of required content is missing	Protocol is incomplete; less than half of required content is missing	Protocol is complete, all sections are included	Protocol is complete, all sections are included and fully developed

components and sections.				
Structure Research protocol is well organized and formatted for optimal readability.	Protocol includes some level of organization though digressions, ambiguities, irrelevances are too many. The protocol is difficult to follow. Headings/transitions are missing or ineffective.	Protocol includes some level of organization though digressions, ambiguities, irrelevances are too many. The protocol is difficult to follow. Headings/transitions are ineffective.	Protocol has a clear organizational structure with some digressions, ambiguities, or irrelevances. Easily followed. Basic transitions Structured format	Protocol is logically organized Easily followed Effective, smooth, and logical transitions Professional format
Synthesis Research protocol demonstrates synthesis of resources, tools, literature search strategies and addresses ethical and diversity considerations.	Protocol demonstrates minimal synthesis; minimally addresses ethical and diversity considerations	Protocol demonstrates some, inconsistently applied synthesis; addresses some ethical and diversity considerations	Protocol demonstrates some, but consistently applied synthesis; addresses more ethical and diversity considerations	Protocol demonstrates full and consistently applied synthesis; addresses extensive ethical and diversity considerations
Integration Research protocol integrates feedback from homework assignments and reflections on course concepts into final proposal.	Demonstrates minimal integration of feedback into revised assignments and reflection	Demonstrates some, inconsistently applied integration of feedback into revised assignments and reflection	Demonstrates some, but consistently applied integration of feedback into revised assignments and reflection	Demonstrates full and consistently applied integration of feedback into revised assignments and reflection
Totals	36	52	64	80

Point system used (i.e., how do course points translate into letter grades)

Points earned	220-204	203-197	196-190	189-182	181-175	174-168	167-160	159-153	152-146	145-138	137-131	>130
Percent of points earned	93-100%	90-92%	87-89%	83-86%	80-82%	77-79%	73-76%	70-72%	67-69%	63-66%	60-62%	Below 62%
Letter Grade	A	A-	B+	B	B-	C+	C	C-	D+	D	D-	E

Passing grades and Grade Points: Credit Earned

Passing Grade	A	A-	B+	B	B-	C+	C	C-	D+	D	D-	E
Grade Points	4.0	3.67	3.33	3.0	2.67	2.33	2.0	1.67	1.33	1.0	0.67	0

Please be aware that a C- is not an acceptable grade for graduate students. The GPA for graduate students must be 3.0 based on 5000 level courses and above to graduate. A grade of C counts toward a graduate degree only if based on credits in courses numbered 5000 or higher that have been earned with a B+ or higher.

More information on UF grading policy may be found in the Grades section of https://gradcatalog.ufl.edu/graduate/regulations/

Policy Related to Make up Exams or Other Work
Assignments turned in late will be discounted **10%** of the grade that they would otherwise receive. Late assignments will be accepted no more than 1 week beyond the due date (except when that extends beyond the end of the course). Late assignments will be accepted through Canvas; make-up assignments for in-class participation will also be assigned in Canvas. In the event of exceptional situations that may interfere with your ability to perform an assignment or meet a deadline, contact the instructor as soon in advance of the deadline as possible. Such special cases will be dealt on an individual basis, provided that you have sufficient documentation.

Please note: Any requests for make-ups due to technical issues MUST be accompanied by the UF Computing help desk (http://helpdesk.ufl.edu/) correspondence. You MUST e-mail us within 24 hours of the technical difficulty if you wish to request a make-up.

Policy Related to Required Class Attendance

Due to the condensed nature of this Summer A course, attendance is required for all regular class meetings. Participation in class discussions are a graded component of this course and regular attendance is required to gain these points.

Requirements for class attendance, assignments, and other work in this course are consistent with university policies that can be found at: https://catalog.ufl.edu/ugrad/current/regulations/info/attendance.aspx

Excused absences must be consistent with university policies in the Graduate Catalog in the Graduate Academic Regulations Section under Attendance Policies on https://catalog.ufl.edu/graduate/regulations/#text

Student Expectations, Roles, and Opportunities for Input
Expectations Regarding Course Behavior: You are expected to maintain a civil tone and respect the opinions of other students. While commenting on others' contributions is encouraged, aggressive or patronizing tone and language are unacceptable and will impact your grade for in-class participation.

Communication Guidelines: We prefer that you contact the instructors by email using the "Inbox" in Canvas for clarification and assistance with the course material and the assignments and for special issues that may arise. Weekday daytime (US Eastern Time) emails have the best chances of being answered quickly. Please only use the Canvas "Inbox" to communicate with the course instructor and/or assisting instructor. While the instructors and their assistants will check their UFL email regularly, emails sent through the Canvas inbox system are likely to be answered faster.

Academic Integrity: Students are expected to act in accordance with the University of Florida policy on academic integrity. As a student at the University of Florida, you have committed yourself to uphold the Honor Code, which includes the following pledge:

"**We, the members of the University of Florida community, pledge to hold ourselves and our peers to the highest standards of honesty and integrity**."

You are expected to exhibit behavior consistent with this commitment to the UF academic community, and on all work submitted for credit at the University of Florida, the following pledge is either required or implied:

"On my honor, I have neither given nor received unauthorized aid in doing this assignment."

It is your individual responsibility to know and comply with all university policies and procedures regarding academic integrity and the Student Honor Code. Violations of the Honor Code at the University of Florida will not be tolerated. Violations will be reported to the Dean of Students Office for consideration of disciplinary action. For additional information regarding Academic Integrity, please see the Student Conduct and Honor Code or the Graduate Student Website for additional details:

Section under Academic Integrity on https://catalog.ufl.edu/graduate/regulations/
https://sccr.dso.ufl.edu/process/student-conduct-code/

Please remember cheating, lying, misrepresentation, or plagiarism in any form is unacceptable and inexcusable behavior.

Online Faculty Course Evaluation Process: Students are expected to provide professional and respectful feedback on the quality of instruction in this course by completing course evaluations online. Students can complete evaluations in three ways:

1. The email they receive from GatorEvals,
2. Their Canvas course menu under GatorEvals, or
3. The central portal at https://my-ufl.bluera.com

Guidance on how to give feedback in a professional and respectful manner is available at https://gatorevals.aa.ufl.edu/students/. Students will be notified when the evaluation period opens. Summaries of course evaluation results are available to students at https://gatorevals.aa.ufl.edu/public-results/.

Policy Related to Guests Attending Class: Only registered students are permitted to attend class. However, we recognize that students who are caretakers may face occasional unexpected challenges creating attendance barriers. Therefore, by exception, a department chair or their designee (e.g., instructors) may grant a student permission to bring a guest(s) for a total of two class sessions per semester. This is two sessions total across all courses. No further extensions will be granted. Please note that guests are not permitted to attend either cadaver or wet labs. Students are responsible for course material regardless of attendance. For additional information, please review the Classroom Guests of Students policy in its entirety.

Support Services
Accommodations for Students with Disabilities: Students with disabilities who experience learning barriers and would like to request academic accommodations should connect with the Disability Resource Center by visiting https://disability.ufl.edu/students/get-started/. It is important for students to share their accommodation letter with their instructor and discuss their access needs as early as possible in the semester. The College is committed to providing reasonable accommodations to assist students in their coursework.

Counseling and Student Health: Students sometimes experience stress from academic expectations and/or personal and interpersonal issues that may interfere with their academic performance. If you find yourself facing issues that have the potential to or are already negatively affecting your coursework, you are encouraged to talk with an instructor and/or seek help through University resources available to you.

- The Counseling and Wellness Center 352-392-1575 offers a variety of support services such as psychological assessment and intervention and assistance for math and test anxiety. Visit their web site for more information https://counseling.ufl.edu/. Online and in-person assistance is available.

- You Matter We Care website: https://umatter.ufl.edu/. If you are feeling overwhelmed or stressed, you can reach out for help through the You Matter We Care website, which is staffed by Dean of Students and Counseling Center personnel.

- The Student Health Care Center at Shands is a satellite clinic of the main Student Health Care Center located on Fletcher Drive on campus. Student Health at Shands offers a variety of clinical services. The clinic is located on the second floor of the Dental Tower in the Health Science Center. For more information, contact the clinic at 392-0627 or check out the website at https://shcc.ufl.edu/.

- Crisis intervention is always available 24/7 from:
  Alachua County Crisis Center:
  (352) 264-6789
  https://www.alachuacounty.us/DEPTS/CSS/CRISISCENTER/Pages/CrisisCenter.aspx

Do not wait until you reach a crisis to come in and talk with us. We have helped many students through stressful situations impacting their academic performance. You are not alone so do not be afraid to ask for assistance.

Inclusive Learning Environment: Public health and health professions are based on the belief in human dignity and on respect for the individual. As we share our personal beliefs inside or outside of the classroom, it is always with the understanding that we value and respect diversity of background, experience, and opinion, where every individual feels valued. We believe in, and promote, openness and tolerance of differences in ethnicity and culture, and we respect differing personal, spiritual, religious and political values. We further believe that celebrating such diversity enriches the quality of the educational experiences we provide our students and enhances our own personal and professional relationships. We embrace The University of Florida's Non-Discrimination Policy, which reads, "The University shall actively promote equal opportunity policies and practices conforming to laws against discrimination. The University is committed to non-discrimination with respect to race, creed, color, religion, age, disability, sex, sexual orientation, gender identity and expression, marital status, national origin, political opinions or affiliations, genetic information and veteran status as protected under the Vietnam Era Veterans' Readjustment Assistance Act." If you have questions or concerns about your rights and responsibilities for inclusive learning environment, please see your instructor or refer to the University of Florida Office of the Ombuds website: https://www.ombuds.ufl.edu/